Live to Tell

By Lisa Gardner

VICTORIA: Please, baby. You know I love you. Please

EVAN: I'm gonna kill you. I'm gonna do it in the middle of the night. But I'll wake you up first. I want you to know. You locked up the knives. You locked up the knives. But did you lock up all the knives? Did you, did you did you? (smiles gleefully)

VICTORIA: My gaze goes instinctively to the drying rack, contents now strewn across the kitchen floor. Had there been a knife in that rack? Had I washed one just this morning? I can't remember, and that's going to cost me. Something is always going to cost me.

EVAN: I will kill you quickly, with a knife. I'll slide the blade in . . . right here (motions to his mother's throat)

VICTORIA: I pour a couple of tablets into the palm of my hand. Slowly, I open his mouth with one finger and poke the first quick-dissolving tablet into the pouch of his cheek. His facial muscles start to relax as the drug takes effect. Ten minutes later, I have him in bed. Now in the silence of the aftermath, I admire the way his hair curves into one golden cowlick right above his left temple, the way his lips always purse slightly in his sleep, lake a baby's. I take his hand, lax now, not hurting, not destroying and hold it in my own. And I wonder if tonight will be the night he will finally kill me.

Meet Evan, my son. He is eight years old.

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INTRODUCTION

A father is gunned down... a mother is bludgeoned to death ... by a son... a daughter... While tabloid television has brought us closer to the everyday horrors of our society, nothing still shocks as much as a child killing a parent. Such an act, though thought uncommon, is almost a daily event in the United States. Between 1977 and 1986, more than 300 parents were killed each year by their own children. In Live to Tell by Lisa Gardner we are witness to the unthinkable decisions that the parents of a seriously emotional disturbed child must make and the impacts that those decisions ultimately have on the family. Live to Tell by Lisa Gardner

[Victoria wakes up in the hospital with her ex-husband dozing in a chair by her bed-side]

VICTORIA: Evan? (panicked)

MICHAEL: How do you feel?

VICTORIA: Th-thirsty. Evan?

MICHAEL: He's OK.

VICTORIA: Chelsea?

MICHAEL: She's at my place, with Melinda. What do you remember? [Victoria notices the pain in her side and the bandages covering the knife wound] The knife penetrated your live. If the EMTs hadn't gotten you here in time for emergency surgery, you would've died.

VICTORIA: Evan?

MICHAEL: Do you understand me, Victoria? You would've died.

VICTORIA: He didn't mean to . . .

MICHAEL: [Angry] You know why I left? You know why I took Chelsea and got the hell out of our home? [Victoria shakes her head, frightened] Because I figured it was only a matter of time before I had to kill my son in order to protect

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my wife and daughter. And call me crazy, but I didn't want to kill Evan. Dammit, I love him too, Victoria. I've always loved him, too.

Do you know what you've done to him? He's eight, and now has to deal with the knowledge that he stabbed his own mother. That he nearly killed you. He's just a kid, for Christ's sake. How's he supposed to handle that? With everything else going on in his messed-up head, how the hell is he ever supposed to deal with that?

I thought you'd died. I got the call, and the way the emergency room nurse was talking . . . I raced all the way here thinking you were dead. That Evan had murdered you. Then I run into the emergency room and the police have a million questions and the doctors have a million questions. I can't even see you; you've already been whisked away to the operating room. And Evan's shackled to a hospital bed. They've got him cuffed and everything. My son. My little boy.

I had to call Darren. I had to get legal advice for Evan. That' where we are with things, Victoria.

VICTORIA: He didn't mean . . . .

MICHAEL: Shut up. Just shut up. I don't care that you're hurt. I don't care that you almost died. I want to hurt you worse, Victoria. I want to slap you until you realize once and for all that your denial is destroying our soon. Even did mean to hurt you. He intentionally stole that goddamn knife out of the drying rack. He cleverly slipped it inside the fabric on the underside of the sofa, where you wouldn't find it. And he carefully retrieved it during an opportune moment, just so he could drive it through your ribs.

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VICTORIA: How do you know all that? How can you possibly know?

MICHAEL: Because he told me. [Victoria is shocked] He's broken. He answered my questions by rote. There's no light in his eyes. He stabbed you, but he broke himself. And I don't know if we'll get him back. Sure this was better than institution, Vic?

VICTORIA: Did . . . did they arrest Evan?

MICHAEL: I'm sure an arrest warrant is only a matter of time. At the moment, however, given his fragile mental state, he's been hospitalized upstairs. Turns out this medical center has a locked-down pediatric psych word on the eighth floor. Evan's now a patient. [Victoria starts to protest]

I don't want to hear it. I had Darren pull our divorce decree. I still have custodial rights to Evan and, given your current physical and emotional state, I'll take you to court and demand full custody if I have to. Our son's experienced a psychotic break. He's upstairs and he's gonna stay there.

VICTORIA: He's just a child . . .

MICHAEL: Which is why it's a pediatric ward.

VICTORIA: Bastard.

MICHAEL: I wish I'd become one sooner. Maybe then we could've avoided this.

VICTORIA: [whispers] I'm not a bad mom.

MICHAEL: No, you're not a bad mom, Vic. And I'm not a bad dad, and Evan, when he's Evan is not a bad kid. And yet, here we are.

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VICTORIA: [Aside/her thoughts] There are so many things I want to tell my son. That I love him. That I still believe in him. I'm not in denial. I've seen the darkness in his eyes. But I've seen the light, too. I've seen all the moments that Evan got to be Evan, and I wouldn't have missed those moments for anything.

[To Michael] You said I was lucky the EMTs got me to the hospital in time. But how did they know? Who called them?

MICHAEL: Evan. He dialed nine-one-one, told the operator he'd stabbed his mother. He said you were bleeding and needed help.

VICTORIA: He tried to save me.

MICHAEL: Maybe. Maybe not. The operator asked him what happened. You know what he said? [Victoria shakes her head, bewildered] He said the Devil made him do it. And he said the ambulance had better come quick, because the Devil wasn't finished yet.

EVAN: [From a locked psych ward] Mommy? Mommy? I just want my mommy. I hurt her. Had the knife. Had to use it. Had to, had to. Nobody loves a boy as naughty as me. Blood is sticky. Warm. Didn't know she'd bleed like that. I didn't know! Mommy. Mommy. Mommy. [Change of persona – softly then growing in intensity] I will get you the next time. Next time I will carve out your heart!

VICTORIA: [Aside / to judge] You try as a parent. You love beyond reason. You fight beyond endurance. You hope beyond despair. You never think until the very last moment that it still might not be enough. No matter what, Evan is my son . . . He is eight years old.

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